

FACING
NORTH



OCTOBER
2026

THE KARAKORAM

*Wellness & Culinary
Journey*

A Women-Led Retreat . Hunza & Skardu

11 DAYS | 10 NIGHTS | WOMEN-ONLY | OCT 09-19, 2026

CALM, MINDFUL, AND DEEPLY SENSORY



The Facing North Experience

A Journey for the Senses and the Soul.

In October, the Karakoram mountains are at their most theatrical: golden autumnal light, apple orchards heavy with fruit, the first dusting of snow on the peaks, and a stillness in the crisp air that invites deep reflection. This journey weaves wellness and culinary discovery into a daily rhythm timed perfectly to the mountains and the light.

**TRAVELER'S
RATING**



MOUNTAIN WELLNESS

Daily yoga, breathwork, and guided meditation (no prior experience required).



CALM PACING

No rushing. Every day has room for the soul to catch up with the body.



DEEP CULINARY

Home-hosted meals, cooking classes, and curated dining showcasing authentic Hunza and Balti cuisine.



CULTURAL CONNECTION

Woman-to-woman exchanges and heritage explorations in Asia's most spectacular valleys.

INTRODUCING YOUR FACING NORTH HOSTS



Najma Mehmood

Hi, I'm Najma, a UK-based cultural curator and community host dedicated to sharing the heritage, landscape, and warmth of Pakistan. I have a deep passion for creating restorative, nature-based spaces for women, which has inspired this dedicated Wellness & Culinary Retreat. This journey is crafted as an intimate, slow-paced, and premium experience designed for women seeking intentional travel and self-connection. Through nourishing local cuisine, wellness practices, and quiet exploration, we aim to offer a deeply grounding and transformational space.

INTRODUCING YOUR FACING NORTH HOSTS



Kehkashan Madeem

Yoga & Mindfulness Host

Known affectionately as “KK,” Kehkashan is a pioneer in Pakistan’s wellness landscape, recognised for introducing Aerial Yoga to the country. A certified RYT 500-hour advanced teacher trainer with 20+ years of experience in Hatha, Ashtanga, and Vinyasa Flow, she trained extensively in Nepal, Thailand, and Bali. Her mountain sessions blend ancient technique with breathtaking natural settings.

The Route

An expedition mapped for the modern explorer. Watch the landscape transform as we leave the capital behind, winding through lush alpine forests, deep glacial valleys, and the ancient, towering peaks of the North.





DAY 1

Arrival & Intentions

Landing Gently, Setting the Tone in Islamabad

THE RHYTHM

Morning

Arrive at Islamabad Airport where our women-led team will warmly welcome you. Transfer to the serene Ambiance Hotel to rest and freshen up.

Afternoon

Ease into the journey with a gentle city introduction—taking in the stunning architecture of Faisal Mosque, soaking in panoramic views from the Margalla Hills, or enjoying a relaxed, sensory walk through Rawalpindi's bustling old bazaar.

Evening

A curated welcome dinner and the opening of our wellness retreat.



Culinary Focus

Welcome dinner curated by Najma, focusing on the philosophy of "mindful eating" and featuring Islamabad's finest seasonal cuisine.

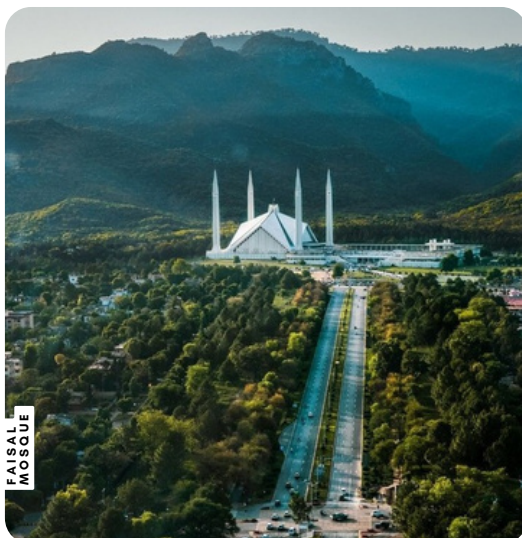


Wellness Focus

KK leads an "Evening Intentions Circle," a safe space to set personal goals and ground yourself for the journey ahead.



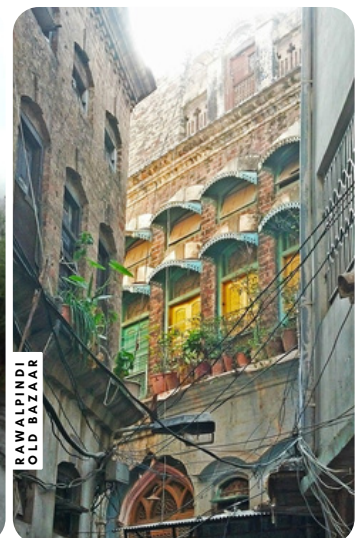
OVERNIGHT AMBIANCE HOTEL



FAISAL
MOSQUE



MARGALLA
HILLS



RAWALPINDI
OLD BAZAAR



DAY 2

Flying into the Karakoram

One of the World's Great Short-Haul Flights

THE RHYTHM

Morning

Begin with one of aviation's most extraordinary experiences: a 45-minute flight to Skardu. The aircraft threads its way between Nanga Parbat, the Karakoram, and the Hindu Kush, offering window views usually reserved for mountaineers.

Midday

Upon landing, we embark on a highly scenic drive north toward the Hunza Valley, tracing winding rivers and towering peaks.

Evening

Arrive at the landmark Serena Hunza Hotel as the October afternoon light turns golden across the valley. Settle in with tea on the terrace while Rakaposhi fills the horizon.

Featured Stay Serena Hunza Hotel



A landmark heritage property perched above the valley with panoramic views of Rakaposhi and Ultar Sar. In October the surrounding poplar trees turn golden, framing the mountains in extraordinary autumn colour.



Wellness Focus

"Air Grounding"—a brief breathwork exercise led by KK upon landing in Skardu, followed by a sunset reflection circle on the Serena terrace in Hunza.



OVERNIGHT SERENA HUNZA HOTEL



SKARDU
FLIGHT VIEW



HUNZA
VALLEY



DAY 3

History in Central Hunza

Stories, Homes & Shared Evenings

THE RHYTHM

Morning

The day begins with sunrise yoga on the Serena terrace & after a nourishing breakfast, we step back 700 years in time with a visit to Baltit Fort. Your guide brings the royal history of Hunza to life through captivating storytelling rather than standard sightseeing.

Afternoon

Enjoy free time to wander the cobblestone lanes of Karimabad, observing local artisans and autumn colors, before heading to a local family's home for lunch.

Evening

We gather for a private, women-only traditional Hunza musical night, complete with a crackling bonfire and warm chai under a canopy of October stars.



Culinary Focus

Home-hosted recipe exchange. Najma facilitates a genuine culinary conversation with local women, exploring apricot oil, dried mulberry chutney, and hand-rolled chapshoro.



Wellness Focus

"Sunrise Mountain Hatha." The flow is timed perfectly to the moment the valley fills with morning sun and Rakaposhi glows pink.



OVERNIGHT SERENA HUNZA HOTEL



SERENA
HUNZA HOTEL



HUNZA
VALLEY



BALTIT FORT



DAY 4

The Mountain Kitchen & Spa

The Most Immersive Day of the Hunza Chapter

THE RHYTHM

Morning

Visit Altit Fort and its surrounding village. Three centuries older than Baltit and perched above the river gorge, this is a quieter heritage site. We then venture into the Hopar Valley, walking among terraced orchards where apple and apricot trees burst with their autumn harvest.

Midday

Head to a local family setting for an immersive, hands-on cooking demonstration.

Evening

The late afternoon and evening are deliberately kept open and unstructured—a rare space to simply sit, breathe, and exist alongside the mountains.

Complimentary
Experience

SERENA SPA



Exclusively arranged for the group as part of this itinerary, a signature wellness session within a Time Magazine World's Greatest Places property. Set at the foot of the Karakoram range, the Serena Spa offers a deeply restorative counterpoint to the days of exploration, perfectly complementing Kehkashan's wellness programme.



Culinary Focus

Mountain Kitchen: hands-on Hunza cooking session with our local host seasonal produce, ancient recipes.



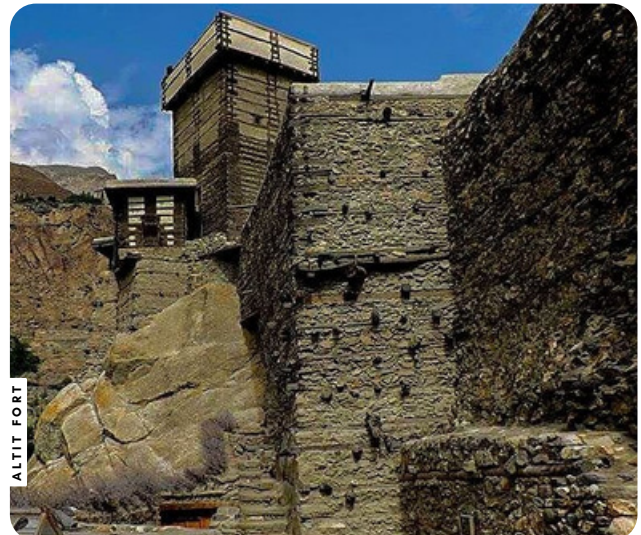
OVERNIGHT
SERENA
HUNZA HOTEL



SERENA SPA



HOPAR
VALLEY



ALTIT FORT



DAY 5

Lakes, Cones & Women's Craft

The Turquoise Waters of Upper Hunza

THE RHYTHM

Morning

We journey into Upper Hunza's dramatic glacial scenery. Take a serene boat ride on Attabad Lake, its turquoise waters contrasting against ochre cliffs, before driving toward the iconic Passu Cones—cathedral-like granite spires.

Midday

Visit a women-led textile cooperative, directly supporting local artisans who handweave traditional Wakhi carpets and intricate embroidered shawls.

Evening

Arrive at your lakeside accommodation to unwind as the October light fades over the water.



Culinary Focus

Najma leads a conversation at the cooperative regarding the intersection of food economics and ancient textile traditions in Upper Hunza.



Wellness Focus

An open-sky meditation facing the Passu Cones, followed by a sunset lakeside yoga sequence at Zen by the Lake.



OVERNIGHT

ZEN BY THE LAKE



ZEN BY THE LAKE



ATTABAD LAKE



PASSU CONES



DAY 6

A Moving Meditation

Through the Mountains to Gilgit

THE RHYTHM

Morning

The day opens with a calm lakeside walk before we begin our drive south. We detour through the lush village of Minapin, taking a short, thrilling jeep ride to an elevated viewpoint for sweeping panoramas of Diran Peak and Rakaposhi.

Midday

Enjoy a rich, community-rooted lunch in Minapin before continuing the drive.

Evening

Arrive in Gilgit. Settle into the hotel and enjoy a leisurely riverside stroll or browse the old bazaar for local handicrafts.



Culinary Focus

Curated lunch at Osho Thang the distinct flavours of Gilgiti mountain cuisine introduced by the local host.



Wellness Focus

KK frames the drive itself as a "Moving Meditation," encouraging periods of mindful silence and observation as the landscapes shift.



OVERNIGHT RAMADA GILGIT HOTEL



SERENA GILGIT
HOTEL



MINAPIN



DIRAN
PEAK



DAY 7

Into Baltistan

Changing Valleys and Glacial Lakes

THE RHYTHM

Morning

Trace the legendary Indus River through the geological heart of Asia. The landscape dramatically shifts from the lush greens of Hunza into the stark, mineral-rich ochres and silvers of Baltistan.

Midday

Pause at Upper Kachura Lake for a short, easy walk through the forest to reach the hidden glacial waters, followed by a peaceful lunch near Lower Kachura Lake.

Evening

Arrive at Hashupi Resort in Skardu. The evening is yours to rest, wander the gardens, and settle into the Balti pace of life.

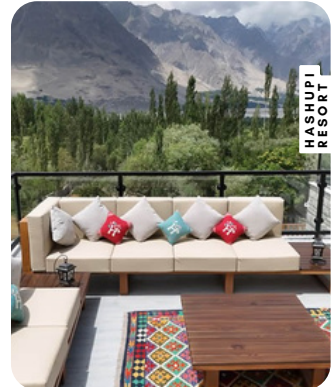
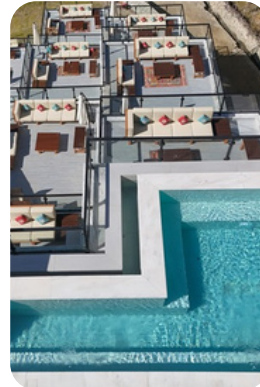


Wellness Focus

Morning breathwork before departing Gilgit, focusing on releasing travel fatigue and preparing the body for the high altitude of Skardu.



OVERNIGHT
HASHUPI
RESORT



HASHUPI
RESORT



KACHURA
LAKE



GILGIT



DAY 8

Heritage & High Altitudes

Shigar Fort to the Cold Desert

THE RHYTHM

Morning

Explore Shigar Fort, a 17th-century Balti Raja's residence lovingly restored by the Aga Khan Trust. Wander through carved wooden chambers and river-facing courtyard gardens.

Midday

After a fort lunch, transition to the surreal Katpana Cold Desert to witness the extraordinary contrast of fine sand dunes rolling directly against 8,000-meter glaciated peaks.

Evening

Return to Hashupi Resort as the sun sets behind the mountains for our evening bonfire.



Culinary Focus

Lunch at Shigar Fort's atmospheric courtyard. Later, Najma presents the distinctive flavors of Skardu's food heritage during a curated Balti dinner.

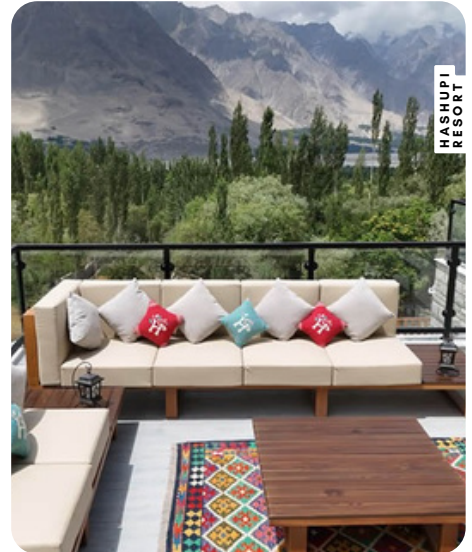


Wellness Focus

Evening Storytelling Circle. KK guides a profound group reflection by the bonfire, touching on vulnerability and the journey so far.



OVERNIGHT HASHUPI RESORT



HASHUPI
RESORT



SHIGAR FORT



KATPANA



DAY 9

The Balti Kitchen

The Most Complete Day in Skardu

THE RHYTHM

Morning

Ascend to Kharpocho, the ancient Balti fortification. Unpack the fort's rich Silk Road history while taking in unparalleled panoramic views across the Skardu basin and the winding Indus River.

Midday

Head to a local Skardu home for deep cultural and culinary immersion, learning the secrets of Baltistan's historic recipes.

Evening

Celebrate the culmination of your time in the North with our final mountain feast.



Culinary Focus

The "Balti Kitchen" hands-on cooking class. Learn to cook marzan, chhurpe cheese, and barley bread baked on a mountain hearth. Evening brings a curated Farewell Skardu Feast.



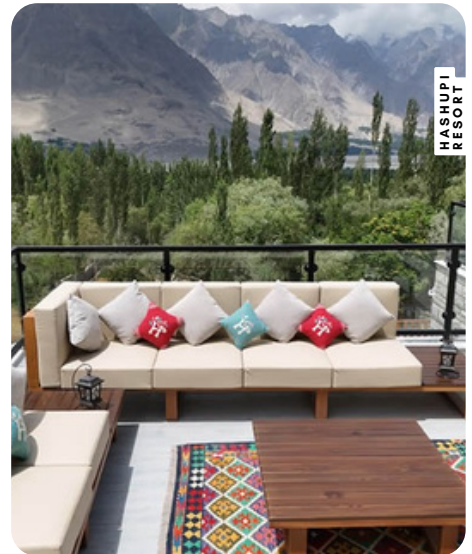
Wellness Focus

Sunrise yoga at Hashupi Resort as the morning sun hits the fort on the ridge above.



OVERNIGHT HASHUPI RESORT

ALL MEALS INCLUDED – FULL BOARD



HASHUPI RESORT



KHARPOCHO



GLIGIT



DAY 10

A Shift in Rhythm

From the Mountains to the Old City

THE RHYTHM

Morning

A morning flight carries the group from the silence of Baltistan back into the capital. And checking in to the Ambiance Hotel followed with a short rest

Midday

Visit to Andhraun Rawalpindi, the living, breathing old city of Rawalpindi with its centuries old bazaars, spice markets, Shah Faisal Mosque views, and the extraordinary sensory energy that only an ancient South Asian marketplace can offer.

Evening

As the sun sets over the Margalla Hills, the group makes their way to Monal Restaurant, Islamabad's most celebrated dining destination.



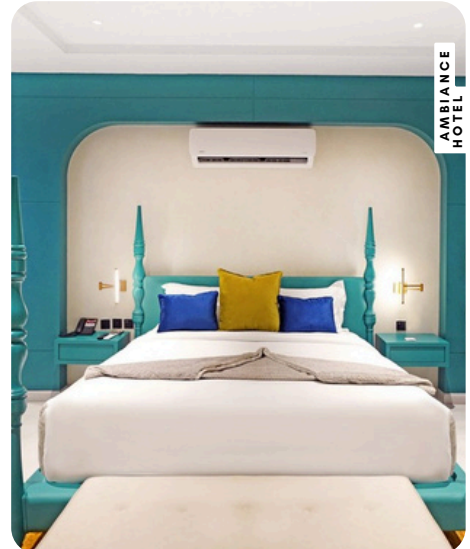
Monal Restaurant

Set on the Margalla Hills overlooking all of Islamabad, Monal is Pakistan's most famous destination restaurant — a fitting final evening as the mountains frame the city one last time. Outdoor terrace seating is arranged for the group. The farewell dinner is included in the package.



OVERNIGHT AMBIANCE HOTEL

ALL MEALS INCLUDED — FULL BOARD



AMBIANCE HOTEL



ANDRAN RAWALPINDI





DAY 11

Farewell To Pakistan

The Journey Within Continues

THE RHYTHM

Morning

Our journey concludes with a leisurely, unhurried final breakfast together at the hotel. It's a morning for sharing memories and savoring the bonds forged over the past ten days.

Midday

After our final closing sessions, guests will check out and take their individual transfers to Lahore Airport (LHE), carrying the spirit of the mountains home with them.



Wellness Focus

KK leads the "Closing Circle"—a guided meditation integrating the people, the mountains, and the journey within.

NOTE

Airport drop-off transfers are not included. Your hotel can arrange a taxi or ride-share on request. International



Inclusions & Exclusions

WHAT'S INCLUDED



ACCOMMODATIONS

10 nights in boutique / heritage lodges

- *Ambiance Islamabad Hotel (1 night)*
- *Serena Hunza Hotel (3 nights)*
- *Zen by the Lake (1 night)*
- *Serena Gilgit Hotel (1 night)*
- *Hashupi Resort, Skardu (3 nights)*
- *Ambiance Hotel, Lahore (2 nights)*



DOMESTIC FLIGHTS

RETURN
Islamabad-Skardu



MEALS

All Meals Included



SERENA SPA

Complimentary Serena Spa
Experience at Serena
Hunza Hotel



WORKSHOPS

All culinary workshops & demonstrations
by Najma Qizilbash



YOGA

All yoga, mindfulness & meditation
sessions led by Kehkashan Nadeem



Private AC Coaster & 4x4 jeeps for all
transfers



TIPS

All drivers, local guides, hotel staff
& restaurants



All entry fees, permits & site charges

WHAT'S NOT INCLUDED

- ✗ International flights to/from Pakistan
- ✗ Visa fees (e-visa usually applied online)
- ✗ Travel insurance (mandatory; must cover high altitude)
- ✗ Lunches on designated free days
- ✗ Personal expenses, shopping & souvenirs
- ✗ Airport drop-off on Day 11 (departure transfer)
- ✗ Personal tip for tour leader (at guest's discretion)



Package cost (GBP)

Group Size	DOUBLE OCCUPANCY (NET)	SINGLE OCCUPANCY (NET)
10-14 Pax	GBP 1,950	GBP. 2,330

Note: All prices mentioned above are per person

Safety, Comfort & Female Support Framework

- **The "Host-Ally" Model:** Kehkashan and Najma provide a dual layer of support, facilitating both your internal wellness journey and your physical experience of the mountains.
- **Cultural Shielding:** Being a female-only group allows for "Zenana" (private female space) access, where guests can interact intimately with local women away from the male gaze.
- **Physical Inclusivity:** All wellness sessions and yoga are "no-pressure" zones, adaptable to individual energy levels and the local altitude.
- **Safe Mobility:** We use vetted, female-friendly vehicles and provide pre-briefed female-centric precautions to ensure guests feel respected and comfortable throughout.

What to Carry

Wellness	Travel yoga mat, meditation cushion, and personal journal for reflection.
Clothing	Layered warm clothing: base layers, fleece, and a windbreaker for mountain conditions.
Modest Attire	Loose cotton tunics covering the hips and a large dupatta for mosques and village visits.
Footwear	Broken-in walking shoes for village walks; slip-on sandals for mosques and wellness sessions.
Documents	At least 10 photocopies of passport and visa for regional checkpoints.

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